



Between 15 and 20 percent of pregnancies in the US end in miscarriage, most of which occur during the first 12 weeks of pregnancy. Being **aware** of the possible causes, **symptoms**, and procedures involved in miscarriages can help you to feel more in control if this happens to you, and to enable you to make **informed choices**.

Miscarriage

What is a miscarriage?

A miscarriage is the spontaneous loss of a pregnancy during the first or second trimester, before a baby has reached 24 weeks gestation. After 24 weeks, a baby is considered “viable,” which means that she is developed enough that if born this early she might be able to survive with specialized medical care. The loss of a baby after 24 weeks is known as a stillbirth (see p.309).

While some miscarriages have a specific cause, such as a structural problem with the uterus or the cervix (see opposite), most miscarriages that occur in the first trimester are thought to be due to a one-time chromosomal abnormality in the fetus. Your risk of miscarriage falls the further into your pregnancy you are, and by the beginning of the second trimester, the risk of miscarriage is around just one percent.

The symptoms of miscarriage can vary and may depend on the type of miscarriage (see box, opposite). You may have a dull ache and a bloody discharge or some spotting, or experience severe periodlike pain, which may be accompanied by heavy bleeding and clots. Sometimes a miscarriage can be symptomless and a woman may be quite unaware that there is anything wrong until a routine ultrasound scan reveals that the fetus has stopped developing in the uterus.

Investigating miscarriages

Each miscarriage is distressing, but it can be some consolation to know that, even if no cause is found, the majority of couples go on to have a healthy pregnancy in the future. About one in 100 couples experience three or more successive miscarriages, known as recurrent miscarriage. If this happens, you are likely to be given tests to try to establish a cause (see p.306). If a cause is found, there may be a treatment that can increase your chances of a successful pregnancy next time. Sometimes no cause is found, and the miscarriages are unexplained. Though upsetting, statistically you are still more likely than not to have a healthy pregnancy in the future.

Moving forward

After a miscarriage, couples need time to grieve and recover. It may take a while before you feel ready, physically and emotionally, to consider trying to become pregnant again, or you may want to try again as soon as possible. If you're undergoing tests or treatment, these can influence when you can try again. If there are no complications and the bleeding has stopped, you and your partner can try again when you feel able. It may be worthwhile to review your lifestyle to maximize your chances of a healthy future pregnancy (see p.29).